

THE TOUCAN

Tucana



SIZE RANKING 48

BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 2.9

GENITIVE Tucanae

ABBREVIATION Tuc

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
September–November

FULLY VISIBLE
14°N–90°S



This far-southern constellation is to be found at the end of the celestial river, Eridanus. It represents the large-beaked tropical bird that is native to South and Central America.

Tucana was introduced in the late 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see p.416).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Tucana contains the Small Magellanic Cloud (see p.311), the lesser of the two satellite galaxies that accompany our own galaxy. To the naked eye, it appears like a detached patch of the Milky Way and is seven times wider than the apparent diameter of a full moon. Star fields and clusters within the Small Magellanic Cloud can be detected through binoculars or a small telescope. It is about 200,000 light-years away.

Two globular clusters lie near the Small Magellanic Cloud, although both are actually foreground objects in our galaxy and so are not associated with the Cloud. The more prominent of the two is 47 Tucanae (see p.294), which looks like a hazy 4th-magnitude star to the naked eye. It apparently covers the same area of sky as a full moon when viewed through binoculars or

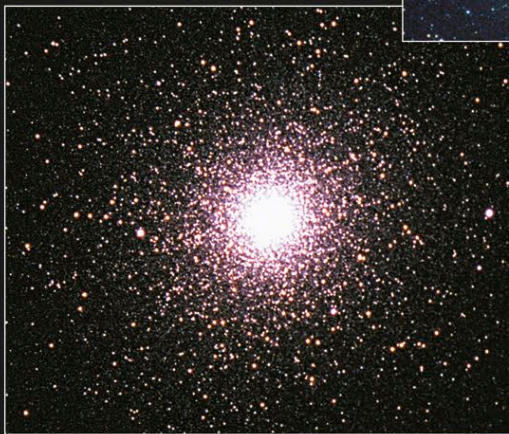
a small telescope. In the entire sky, only Omega (ω) Centauri is a more impressive globular cluster than 47 Tucanae. NGC 362, the other globular cluster in Tucana, is smaller and fainter and requires binoculars or a small telescope to be seen.

Beta (β) Tucanae is a naked-eye or binocular double with stars of 4th and 5th magnitudes. The brighter component can be further separated through a telescope. Kappa (κ) Tucanae, near NGC 362, is a double star of 5th and 7th magnitudes divisible through a small telescope.



THE SMC

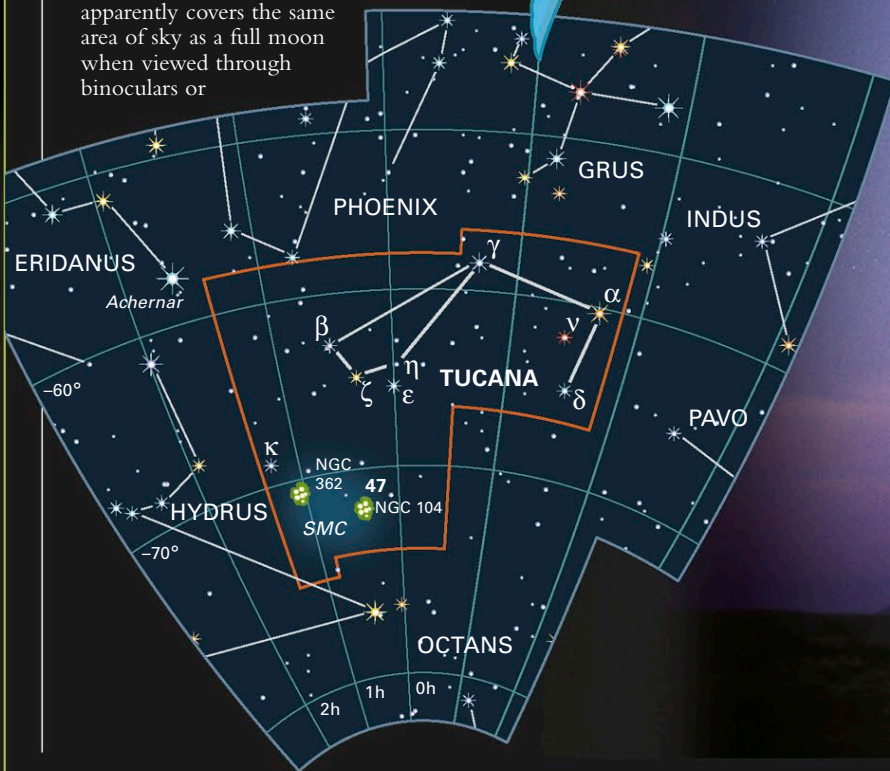
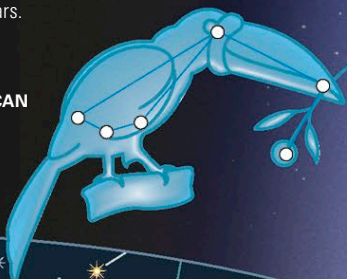
This neighboring mini-galaxy, the Small Magellanic Cloud, appears noticeably elongated. To its right in this image lies 47 Tucanae, or NGC 104, a globular cluster in our galaxy.



47 TUCANAE

This bright globular cluster looks like a fuzzy star on wide-angle photographs like the one above right, but telescopes reveal it to be an immense swarm of stars.

THE TOUCAN



BIRD OF THE SOUTHERN SKIES

The Toucan's huge beak points downward as the constellation sets toward the western horizon. North is to the right in this picture.